

1.2 Open Source—Where Everyone Can Be A Developer

OK, that sounds a little too optimistic. But then that's what open source proponents claim. You've most probably encountered the term "open source" somewhere—in a magazine, on TV, with peers, or even in a newspaper. Before we proceed to install and play with Linux, it helps to understand just what open source is. After all, Linux and open source are often uttered in the same breath. So what's open source all about?

A source code is the program code exactly as it is written by the programmer: the raw code that is not compiled and is editable is the source code. (Compilation is the process of finalising a code for execution.) For an operating system, the source code runs into several thousands of lines that appears "as written." (Needless to say, deciphering the logic behind the source code can be quite a task even for a competitive programmer.)

Since the source code is in raw, uncompiled format, anyone who has access to it can make his own additions, deletions or changes—and hence his own versions of the software with modified or added features. Obviously, with more people working on developing OSes and applications, the number of variations and innovations are huge, and open up exciting possibilities—because we can have developers all across the globe working towards creating new software. These developers need not work for a particular company or for direct monetary benefit. Enthusiasts can contribute to mainstream software. Students can learn the insides of software. All this, of course, only when the source code of the software is made freely available. And that is what the open source idea is all about.

1.2.1 Free Software

A closely-related but not similar idea is that of free software. Free software means, well, that the software is available for free. It is already compiled and ready to use. Open source only means the source code is available to whoever wishes to build around it and make fully-functional software. Free software need not be open